

Every human will be defined by the augmentations they carry; it will mean the end of jealousy, of the concept of talent, but will also spell the end of art and uniqueness.

To elaborate, we are defined by our all-too-human qualities such as confidence, motivation, inhibitions, love, hate, and so on and so forth. In cyborgdom, these will mean nothing, as we could simply augment any quality at will. You could choose to play the guitar as wonderfully as Joe Satriani does, paint like Michelangelo, or bat like Virender Sehwag; all you need to do is choose. You could choose to alter your feelings so you begin to actually hate someone you love, or to love someone you hate. You could even go as far as changing your physical feeling of heat or cold, and decide to shiver in the summer and sweat in the winter. The possibilities



Will we all become "nodes on the Internet," as Warwick says? The possibility of a eugenically-enhanced, mass-produced population is real, and very scary

are endless, and limited only by the imagination.

Is this ethical? Debates already rage about mind-altering substances—recreational drugs as well as prescription medications. What kind of debates would begin once such implants became available?

Anti-implant advocates would essentially say that the use of implants is unfair, that it gives an unfair edge to those who can afford them. In the beginnings of the rush to the cyborg state, then, would be another Digital Divide: the implanted rich and the only-human poor.

Eugenics

Ultimately, all this could boil down to the classic have and have-not situation, where the rich can afford to live forever, while the poor die dreaming of better lives. It could also lead to more serious scenarios, where implants are restricted to certain countries or races. Imagine the western world living forever as cyborgs, with third-world countries suffering in the human condition. The last thing mankind needs is another Hitleresque vision, where someone decides who lives and who doesn't.

Nature

Do we have an idea about what will happen to the race if we rush ahead to embrace a wired future? In fact, do we have an idea, even now, of what it means to be human? If we have no defining idea what humanness means, how can we possibly know what it will be like to lose it?

What has the human race done thus far? We were born into nature, comprehended and won over it, and destroyed half the planet. We built inhuman cities where people lead artificial lives, alienated from nature; we fell prey to diseases that are caused because of this disharmony with nature.

What this points to is that even in the purely human state, we never did comprehend the essential need for the bond with nature; and so, how can we expect to understand what will happen when that bond is broken altogether—as will happen when we turn cyborg?

Death

Returning to the question of immortality: will we not be toying with the natural balance of the planet if people were to live, say, for 300 years or more? Think overpopulation. And who would decide when and why someone was to die, if the need arose to kill off some people when the need to reduce the population arose?

This has a strong link with what we had to say about eugenics. Who gets to live, and who gets killed? Can we comprehend the power structure and government that would be necessary to manage such a world, where nature is not in control any more?

And what if a particular individual decided to live on indefinitely—would such a life be worth it? The question is pertinent because that's where we're rushing to: one of the defining qualities of Utopia in cyborgdom is the possibility of living as long—and as happily—as one wanted to.

A quote from Anglo-American novelist Susan Ertz is in order here: "Millions long for immortality who don't know what to do with themselves on a rainy Sunday afternoon."

This is, of course, one point of view: there are many who would maintain that immortality is the way to go. And this is a deeply philosophical question as well—whether to die or not. We will not go into that here. Suffice it to say that such questions will become more and more pertinent as we move into the wired future with its extended life-spans.

The 'Matrix' Trap

When we achieve the levels of automation required to support human beings on run-of-the-mill life support systems, without the need to eat, the human being will have an option. Some aver that this will open up the avenues required for people to finally do what is worth doing: creativity will be unleashed, entertainment will be on-the-spot, and the struggle for survival will be gone.

But the cyborg will necessarily fall prey to inertia. He will have the option to choose entertainment exclusively and indulge in nothing else. He will have the option to lie in the permanent state of artificial stimulation of the senses. This raises the spectre of a *Matrix*-like situation, where a powerful few govern the sleeping, experience-immersed majority.

To see how this is a very real possibility, think again of recreational drugs. It is a known fact that laboratory rats prefer cocaine to food, and will starve to death given the option—continually choosing the offered cocaine rather than the food.

We know very well how strong the drive towards inertia is. And if the drive towards inertia is so powerful, what about the drive to an entertained inertia—